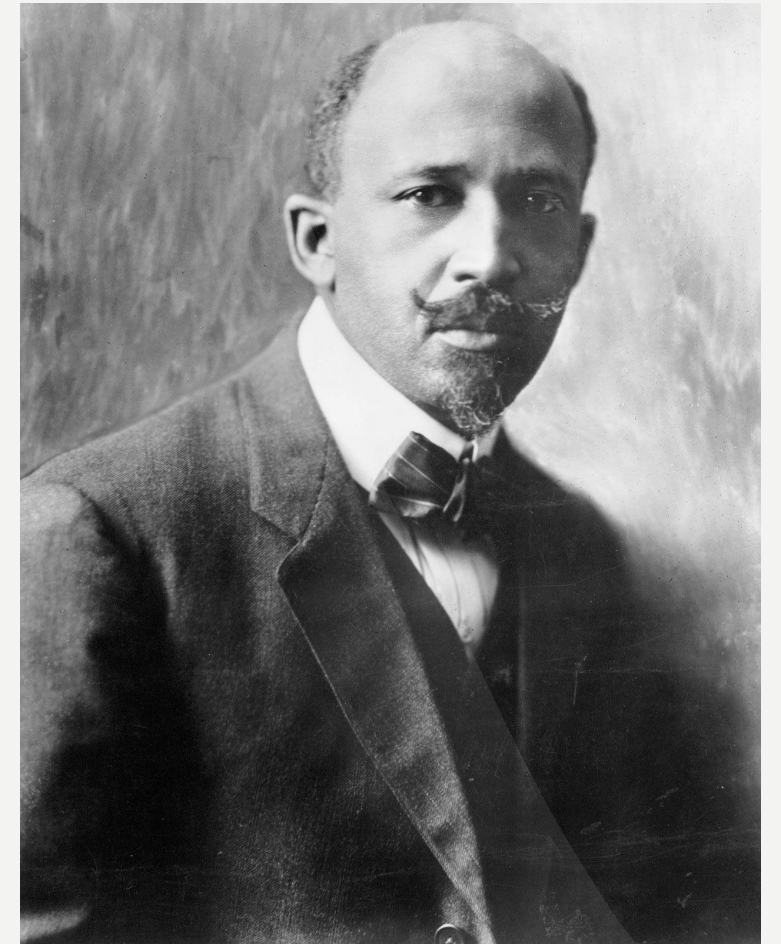
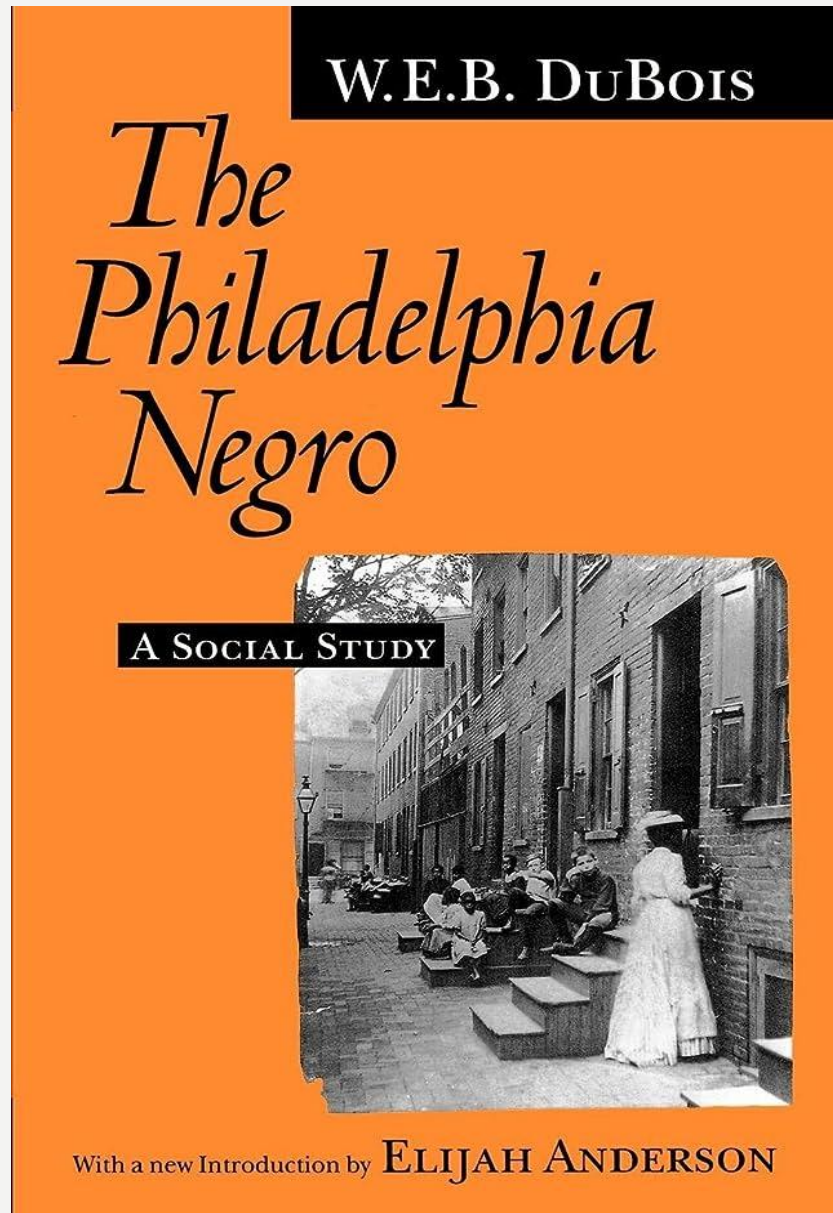


W.E.B DU BOIS
“THE PHILADELPHIA
NEGRO” (1899)



W.E.B. Du Bois
(1868-1963)

OUTLINE

- 1.** The author and the context
- 2.** The research
 - 1.** Fieldwork
 - 2.** Results
- 3.** A sociological perspective
- 4.** Public sociology and political engagement

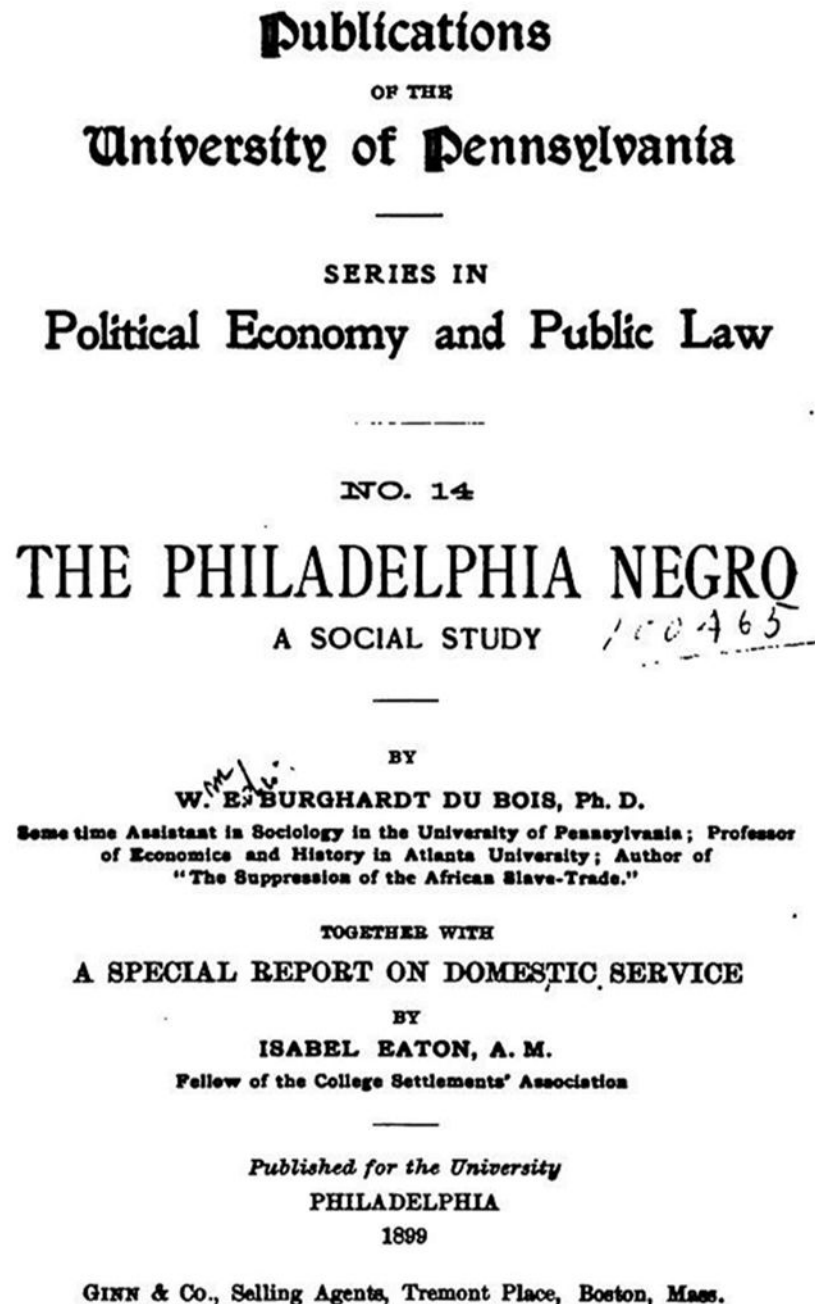
1. THE AUTHOR

- 1895: PhD, Harvard.
- 1899 : publishes *The Philadelphia Negro*.
- 1903 : *The Souls of Black Folks*
- 1909 : founds the NAACP and « The Crisis »
- 1934-1944 : professor at Atlanta University
- 1944-1948 : leaves university to do research for the NAACP
- 1961 : member of the communist party
- 1963 : dies in Ghana.



His approach:

- He is critical of those who want to explain the situation of black people with « philosophical » arguments without empirical evidence.
- He wants to take a « scientific » approach by examining all facts.
- Multiple methods and data sources: observation, interviews, questionnaires, documents. Holistic approach.
- The aim of his research is to contribute to find solutions and to provide better conditions for black people.
- Context: Jim Crow laws and segregation.



2. THE RESEARCH

The « Negro problem »

Employers :

- University of Pennsylvania
- S. P. Wharton, a local philanthropist

Research team :

- W.E.B. Du Bois
- Isabel Eaton
- University students

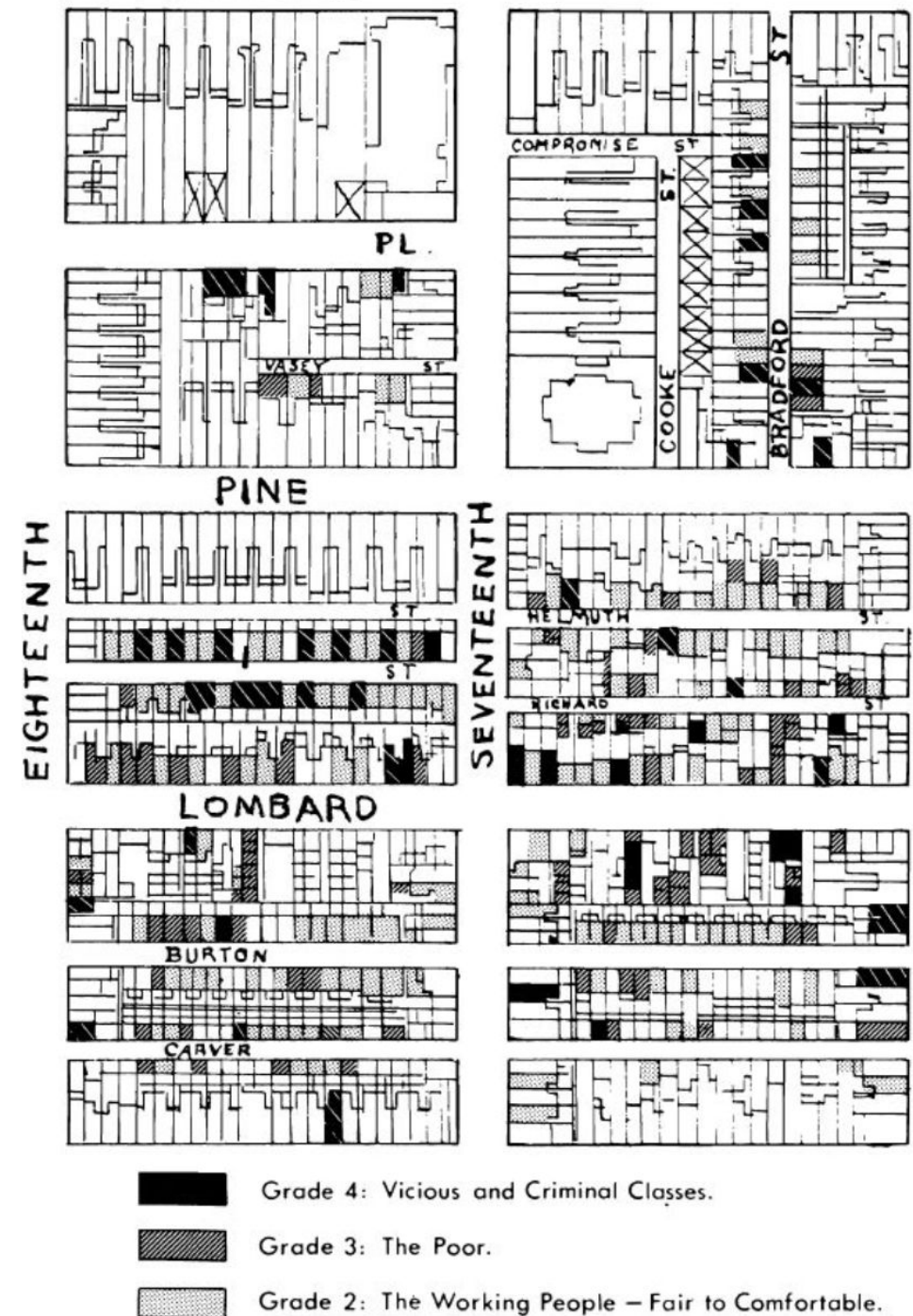
The field :

- Philadelphia, 7th district
- Main African-American neighbourhood in the city
- The 4th city in the USA with more black residents.
- Migration
- The problem: why do black people not participate in society in the same way as whites?



2.1. METHODS

- Questionnaires (5,000 respondents), and interviews
 - Observation (participant)
 - Statistical analysis (maps, tables)
 - Documents and archives
-
- Analysis of “external” and “internal” dynamics in the community.



Main topics explored:

- 1) External dynamics (environmental):
 - Physical: quality and characteristics of the houses, roads, ventilation, garbage disposal, cleanliness, transportation...
 - Social : racial discrimination in all domains of social life (employment, housing, health, education...).
- 2) Internal dynamics:
 - Social stratification
 - Socialisation patterns
- 3) « Racial prejudice » as a central concept.

2.2. RESULTS

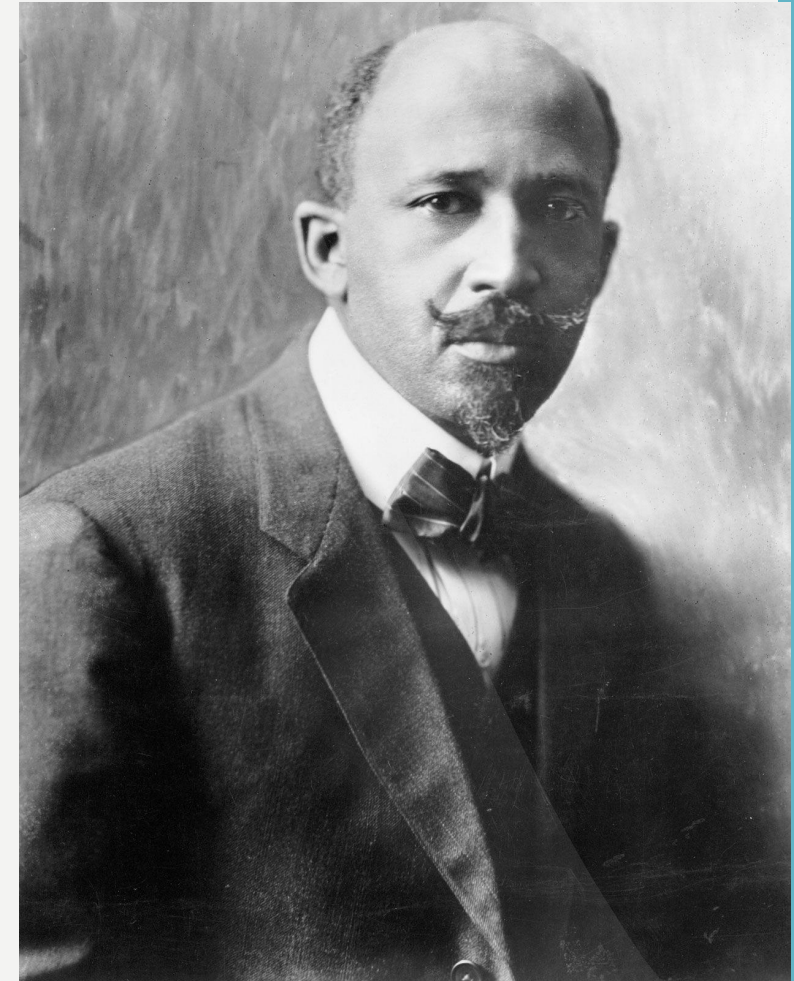
- The neighbourhood is a « city within the city », a community closed to the rest of the city.
- Social stratification is very present. The « élites » try to keep the other classes at a distance.
- The residents are social pariahs, they are constantly exposed to discriminations in all areas of life.
- Levels of criminality are high, but they are a consequence of racial discrimination and prejudice.
- Racial prejudice causes discrimination, which in turn influences the environment and living conditions, which cause poverty and criminality.
- There is not a « Negro problem » but rather a « white problem ».

3. A SOCIOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVE

- The first sociological study on race.
- “Deconstructing” the biological idea of race:
 - Departing from biological arguments and the idea of race as biological.
 - Race as a relational category, that is related to hierarchies and power relations.
 - Racial prejudice is a self-fulfilling prophecy.
 - Racial prejudice varies by individuals and social groups, and throughout history: it can therefore be eliminated.
- Using rigorous empirical methods to back the arguments and to examine social phenomena relevant to the topic.
- A pioneer of “relational sociology”, linking individual behaviors and structural factors.
- Not very succesful at the time in academia.

Du Bois does not support the idea of « value freedom » as a requirement for scientific objectivity.

“Students must be careful to insist that science as such – be it physics, chemistry, psychology, or sociology – has but one simple aim: the discovery of truth. Its results lie open for the use of all men – merchants, physicians, men of letters, and philanthropists, but the aim of science itself is simple truth. Any attempt to give it a double aim, to make social reform the immediate instead of the mediate object of a search for truth, will inevitably tend to defeat both objects. (...) Only by such rigid adherence to the truth object of the scholar, can statesman and philanthropists of all shades of belief be put into possession of a reliable body of truth which may guide their efforts to the best and largest success.”



- “The object of these studies is primarily scientific – a careful search for truth conducted as thoroughly, broadly, and honestly as the material resources and mental equipment at command will allow; but this is not our sole object; we wish not only to make the Truth clear but to present it in such shape as will encourage and help social reform”

This has to do with his understanding of democracy:

- “Democracy is not merely a distribution of power among a vast number of individuals. It is not merely majority rule based on the fact that the majority has the physical force to prevail. It is something far more fundamental than this: it rests upon the fact that when we have proven knowledge, interpreted through the experience of a large number of individuals, it is possible through this pooled knowledge and experience to come to decisions much more fundamental and much more far reaching that can be had in any other way.”

And would lead to a final position when science and political activism must go hand in hand.

4. PUBLIC SOCIOLOGY

- Many early empirical studies addressed public problems trying to find a solution (for poverty, unemployment, public health, crime...)
- But different perspectives developed:
 1. Research that addresses a clearly identified social problem.
 2. Research that uncovers a social problem that had not been identified as such.
 3. Research that does not address a specific “social problem”, but can provide analytical tools applicable to social problems.

Can you think of examples of these three?

“In a sense, sociology is always “public” and related to social problems”, would you agree with this?

Matthew Desmond

EVICTED



POVERTY AND PROFIT IN
THE AMERICAN CITY

'Extraordinary and crucial. Read it. Please, read it.'
Adrian Nicole LaBlanc